

MAKING A PERFECT SCORE BETTER

WITH TWO PREVIOUS CLEAN SWEEPS, THE BJP SITS PRETTY IN UTTARAKHAND. THE CHALLENGE BEFORE IT IS TO WIN BY EVEN BIGGER MARGINS

By Anilesh S. Mahajan *in Dehradun*

In the assembly election held in March 2022, Uttarakhand chief minister Pushkar Singh Dhami defied psephologists, anti-incumbency and a history of no incumbent party being re-elected. Winning 47 seats and 44.3 per cent of the votes, his return to power was emphatic. Two years later, Dhami is back on the campaign trail, hoping to retain all the state's five seats that the BJP won in the 2019 polls. The state goes to the polls on April 19, when 8.4 million voters would exercise their franchise. Sixty per cent of voters are younger than 48-year-old Dhami, who is wooing them with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of a Viksit Bharat, while showcasing his own government's work.

"Infrastructure projects like construction of highways, bridges, roads, upgradation of airports and rail links are on track or completed, social sector schemes have reached remote parts, an ecosystem is being created to build entrepreneurial capacities. Now it's the turn of the voters to show support," Dhami tells INDIA TODAY. Dhami, who was made chief minister after Trivendra Singh Rawat and Tirath Singh Rawat resigned as CMs in 2021, understands that 2024 will be a mid-term referendum on his performance.

With all five LS seats won twice over—in 2014 and 2019—with a 55 per cent vote share, Uttarakhand is a saffron bastion. Studded with holy Hindu shrines, including the Char Dham, the pull of Hindutva is keenly felt here, and PM Modi has sedulously catered to it by often visiting pilgrimage sites like Kedarnath. At a rally in Rudrapur on April 2, Modi recounted the development works of the BJP government in Uttarakhand, gave a 'guarantee' of free electricity and taunted the Congress for having an "Emergency-era mentality without faith in democracy". Uttarakhand has also been a laboratory for the BJP's ideological push—it was the first state to pass a Uniform Civil Code law in February.



"IN AN INTENSE POLITICAL BATTLE, SOCIAL GROUPS SEE WHO IS IN A BETTER POSITION TO WIN. THEY DON'T WANT TO END UP AS VOTE-SPLITTERS AND HELP THEIR RIVALS"

HARISH RAWAT *Congress leader, Former Chief Minister, Uttarakhand*

The Congress, meanwhile, is trying hard to check PM Modi's pull among the masses. "We are picking up real issues like lack of jobs and poor development," says Uttarakhand Congress chief Karan Mahara. "These are the real pain points that people feel in their daily lives."

The BJP has fielded former CM Trivendra Rawat from Haridwar against